GLASSHOUSE

TACTICAL TAKEDOWN

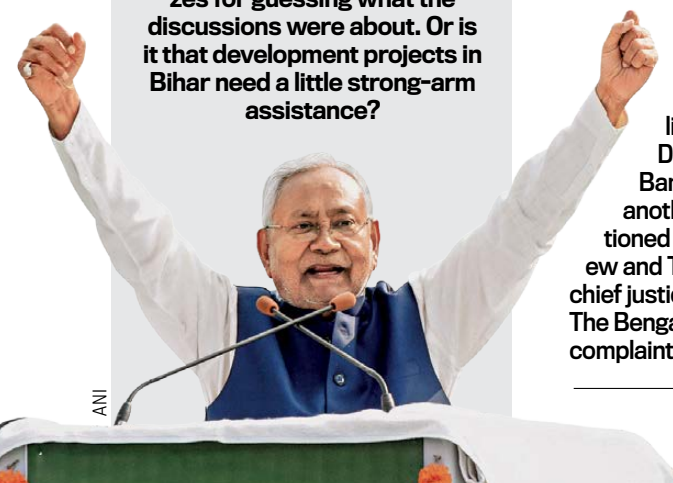
On September 6, Olympian wrestlers **Vinesh Phogat** and **Bajrang Punia**—who were among the faces of the sexual harassment protests against former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief and ex-BJP MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh—joined the Congress. Phogat bagged a ticket for the assembly election in Haryana while Punia, well, got a handshake and a "next time, for sure" nod. This, despite **Rahul Gandhi** reportedly insisting he had promised the wrestler a ticket during his Bharat Jodo Yatra. Phogat, of course, comes with a truckload of public sympathy, courtesy of her stellar Olympic performance and the heartbreak that followed in Paris. So what happened with Punia? Apparently, the Congress didn't want it to look like a Jat wrestling bout, lest they spook the other communities into the BJP's arms.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

DON OUT AND ABOUT

On September 10, while on an official tour to flag off development projects, Bihar CM Nitish Kumar stopped at the village of former MLA Anant Singh, the don who dropped the JD(U) for the RJD in 2020. The bahubali, who came out of jail in August but still has over three dozen criminal cases against him, welcomed Nitish and, later, personally saw him off too. The cosy reunion was their second in two weeks, after Anant's recent acquittal in an illegal arms (AK-47 and grenade launcher, no less) case. Anant is eyeing a comeback in the 2025 assembly poll, so no prizes for guessing what the discussions were about. Or is it that development projects in Bihar need a little strong-arm assistance?



ANI



HANDS-ON TROUBLE

Sandip Ghosh, the disgraced ex-principal of Kolkata's R.G. Kar Medical College, seems to be no stranger to police custody. Back in April 2017, Ghosh, who is now under the lens after the rape-murder of a female junior doctor in the college, found himself behind bars in Hong Kong's Kowloon City after a male nurse of the Queen Elizabeth Hospital there allegedly accused him of 'inappropriate touching'. Ghosh's defence? He was just trying to get his dislocated shoulder fixed and his hand "accidentally" wandered. Ghosh was then head of the orthopaedic department at Murshidabad Medical College and had gone to Hong Kong as part of a clinical attachment programme.

Justice Jitters



Chief Justice of India **D.Y. Chandrachud** has consistently emphasised the need for "judicial wellness", and putting a stop to the rampant spread of fake news. The CJI himself was in the eye of a storm recently while presiding over a suo motu case regarding the R.G. Kar Medical College rape-murder case. Fake reports surfaced linking the CJI's wife, Kalpana Das, to West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee's personal physician, while another suggested the CJI had vacationed in Thailand with Mamata's nephew and TMC No. 2 Abhishek Banerjee. The chief justice's office swiftly issued a denial. The Bengal police, too, have filed a cyber complaint in the matter.

Dynasty Duels



In Maharashtra's ongoing political soap operas, it's time for the next episode: a father vs daughter battle. Bhagyashri Atram, daughter of NCP minister and local Gadchiroli royalty **Dharmaraobaba Atram**, may challenge her dad as a candidate for the rival Sharad Pawar faction of the NCP. Atram Sr is already on the attack, asking voters to throw daughter and son-in-law "in the Pranhita river for treachery".

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Dhaval S. Kulkarni